tourism is the top reason why people travelled in 2025-2026, leisure and recreation accounted for 36.4 per cent of urban overnight trips, against just 12.5 per cent in rural areas. In contrast, health and medical travel accounted for 16.5 per cent in urban areas, compared to 38.4 per cent of rural trips.

Today, different traveller profiles have emerged and all are growing fast, whether they are solo travellers, women-only groups, men-only groups, or young couples and families, says Rajesh Magow, co-founder and group CEO, MakeMyTrip. Gen Z and young working couples are among the fastest growing traveller segments today. Another new addition is group travel. DTES 2024-2025 says urban households prefer to travel in bigger groups mostly for religious trips whereas in rural areas the maximum number of people travel together for holiday and recreation.



"Today, different traveller profiles have emerged.... Gen Z and young working couples are among the fastest growing"

— RAJESH MAGOW
Co-founder & Group CEO, MakeMyTrip

The DTES also points to differences in how urban and rural Indians travel. For overnight trips, trains were the most popular option (35.1 per cent) among urban households; among rural households, buses were the most commonly used mode of transport (32 per cent).

One fundamental change taking place in the country is the premiumisation of travel, where travellers across segments are looking for better experiences. Nikhil Sharma, MD & COO of South Asia, Radisson Hotel Group, lets on that they have a hundred new hotels in the pipeline, with half of them in Tier 3 and 4 cities. The shift towards better accommodation, though, is not uniform across the country. Among urban households, hotels and guesthouses were preferred (35.9 per cent of stays, up from 25.8 per cent in 2014-2015). The drastic change is in rural areas, where only 41 per cent of households now looked at non-commercial accommodation (free religious lodging, friends/family, etc.), a big drop from over 91 per cent in 2014-2015.

Travel experts say the next phase of India's tourism growth will depend not just on people travelling or destinations discovered, but on whether cities and towns can deliver a consistent, quality experience. ■

THE GRAND RUSH FOR FAITH

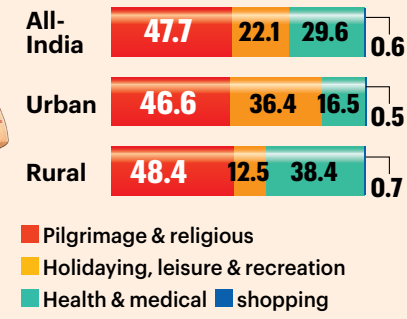
Led by GenZ, millions are now combining pilgrimage with leisure. A tourism ecosystem is slowly taking shape around this new travel preference

REASONS TO TRAVEL

Nearly half of all overnight trips within India are for religious reasons, followed by health and medical trips. Urban households take more holidays than rural ones, who travel more for healthcare purposes



Overnight trips completed in the past 365 days (%)



EXPENSE IN OVERNIGHT TRAVEL

Religious trips cost the least, while health and medical trips are the most expensive, followed by shopping, and holidaying, leisure and recreation

	Urban	Rural
Pilgrimage & religious	₹9,920	₹6,269
Holidaying, leisure and recreation	₹13,190	₹8,890
Health & medical	₹41,649	₹29,454
Shopping	₹24,170	₹16,388

** Average expenditure per overnight trip completed in the past 365 days*

Source: Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey July 2025-June 2026